Borders, Accents and Weapons

By Denice Frohman

INTRODUCTION

In the words of Julian Castro, former Mayor of San Antonio, ". . . the American dream is not a sprint, or even a marathon, but a relay. Our families don't always cross the finish line in the span of one generation. But each generation passes on to the next the fruits of their labor."

These days, more than ever, we need words of wisdom, inspiration, and empowerment in the Latino community. When so many are spewing hateful words, we must remind ourselves of all the talent, goodness and strength that lives within us.

The resilience, work ethic, and beauty of the Hispanic community lifts every corner of this country, and yet . . . There are still some borders you can't cross by foot.

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Borders (Pg 86-89)

It starts before she gets here.
before the stairs tell her she is alien
to a country that knows her great
grandfather's Mexican hands all too well.
His fingerprints still echo underneath
the railroad tracks and cotton fields
where bent knees and bent backs
once picked, plucked, pushed work
for more money than he was used to,
but less than he deserved.

For Ana Maria, it begins before the border.
She walks with her two Uncles and Abuela
through the desert for one week
with nothing more than a few gallons of water,
and a prayer tucked into their pockets,
hoping both will last them long enough.

The sun is an unforgiving God, but any God
is worth having right now.
The wind pushing at their backs
is the grunt of gunshots from drug cartels

and the desperation of a job to employ their stomachs.
Both have been uninvited guests at their doorstep.

so they step, step,
Ana Maria's small hand clutches the bottom
of her Abuela's dress,
another step,
her mother waits for her on the other side
hoping that her face still sings of home like it used to.
another step,
She is too young to know what "border" means,
she thinks that people
are just family members who haven't met yet.

After they arrive,
she will learn there are
some borders you can't cross by foot.

Ana Maria is now 10 years old.
She's learned enough English to translate for her parents,
but says that her thick accent is still a problem
she tries to fix by leaving it in her locker.
When her teacher calls on her to read
she tries to speak proper. Like proper has a sound.

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She pushes her tongue down so it doesn't roll her "r's,"
but she trips on the flatness of the syllables
that usually bounce with too much salsa.
She tries to rattle out the kinks in her speech,
but her tongue is a stubborn dancer.

The two boys behind her don't know how to do long
division,
but they know what a wetback is,
and that Ana Maria has braids,
and that Ana Maria's hair is thicker than their sister's,
and they don't know how they know,
but they know how to treat difference when they smell it.
So they say things like, "Go back to your country,"
as if their Irish ancestors never walked through Ellis Island.

Ana Maria is now 16.
Her father works 18-hour days as a dishwasher.
Her mother cleans houses she'll never get to live in
so that Ana Maria can sit in a college classroom
and say, "I am here."

But her guidance counselor says she can't get financial

aid,

or the in-state tuition rate, because of her status.

She says it like an apology.

Ana wonders if her family ever crossed the border,

or if they are just stuck inside another one,

aggravating it like a sore.

Her guidance counselor stands in front of her,

with a mouth full of fences.

There are some borders you can't cross by foot.

Borders, I tell her,

that can only be crossed by stubborn backbones

so if they ask you for your papers, show them your skin,

wear your tongue like a cape,

throw up your fist, like a secret you can't keep any longer,

they can't keep you any longer,

afraid you can't ever afford to drive or dream.

So if they come for you, tell them

in the language you know best,

that you are not scared anymore.

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TRANSITION

The language I know best is Spanish. ***Mi familia habla español casi exclusivamente en casa.*** *And I often help translate for them. I am blessed with two languages – Spanish and English. But my mom? She holds her accent like a shotgun . . .*

Accents

my mom holds her accent like a shotgun,

with two good hands.

her tongue,

all brass knuckle

slipping in-between her lips.

her hips are all laughter

and wind clap.

she speaks a sancocho of spanish and english,

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pushing up and against one another in rapid fire.
there is no tellin' my mama to be "quiet."
she don't know "quiet."
her voice is one size
better fit all and you best not
tell her to hush. she waited
too many years for her voice to arrive
to be told it needed house-keeping.
english sits in her mouth, remixed
so "strawberry" becomes ***eh-strawbeddy***
and "cookie" becomes ***eh-cookie***
and kitchen, key chain, and chicken
all sound the same.
my mama doesn't say, "yes."
she says, ***ah ha***
and suddenly
the sky in her mouth
becomes a Hector Lavoe song.
her tongue
can't lay itself down
flat enough
for the english language.

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it got too much hip.
too much bone,
too much conga,
too much cuatro
to two step.
got too many piano keys
in between her teeth.
it got too much clave,
too much hand clap, got
too much salsa to sit still.
it be an anxious child
wanting to make play-doh
out of concrete. english be too neat
for her kind of wonderful.
her words spill in conversation
between women whose hands are all they got.
sometimes our hands are all we got,
and accents remind us that we are still
bomba, still plena.
say, "wepa!"
and a stranger becomes your hermano.
say, "dale!"

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and a crowd becomes a family reunion.

my mama's tongue is a telegram from her mother

decorated with the coqui's of el campo,

so even when her lips can barely

stretch themselves around english,

her accent

is a stubborn compass

always pointing her

towards home.

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AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier (Combined with other poems)

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TRANSITION

Families are safe havens . . . as they should be. Another safe haven should be our schools. But for students, especially students of color, 'Do You Have Weapons?' is heard more often than 'Do You Have Dreams?' Poet Denice Frohman points out that there are many manifestations of violence. Not just the physical, but something cultural, emotional and psychological that must be addressed.

Weapons

At entrance of a West Philadelphia high school, an officer

with a gun perched on each waist,

asks me if I have any weapons. I hold up my book.

He doesn't find that funny. Tells me to empty pockets,

walk through metal detector.

8:03am.

I wait for 2 students to pass through first. Already I

wonder what they have learned.

I am escorted to an auditorium, where there are 130 Black

and Latino students.

We talk about hip-hop, they think poetry is what old white

people do.

I tell them my favorite poem is "Ms. Fat Booty"

because I like the storytelling. They giggle as if they are still kids.

One girl shouts her favorite song is, "Rack City, bitch!" And the whole room explodes in unison,

their bodies bouncing as if they were dancing on trampolines.

I ask them if they have dreams. 11 students raise their hands,

barely above their shoulders as if they were sitting in History class

unsure of the right answer.

One student in the first row named Luciano is waiting for me to tell him what page to turn to.

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Another student, in the 8th row studies my face, trying to decide if this

is a trick question.

There is no right answer, I say but they are far too comfortable

with the right to remain silent.

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So I ask them do you have a family member in prison, 122 students mechanically raise both

of their hands, as if a string, tied around their wrists, was yanked for them.

Their hands remain up this time. And I can see all of them, perfectly.

I heard the newly built prison a few miles away bought their test scores as wallpaper.

The principal is now staring at me in anticipation of what I have to say next.

He is afraid they will leave with weapons. I am afraid they will not know the ones that already exist.

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